community to vote en masse for the SP was responsible for the disaster. She had also blamed "casteist" forces for convincing dominant castes, Dalits and OBCs to vote for the BJP to stave off an "SP jungle raj". The defeat, she had said, was a "lesson" that would guide the party's strategy. Now, she has started inducting heavyweight Muslim leaders in her party. Besides Masood, ex-MLA Shah Alam, a.k.a. Guddu Jamali, from east UP has joined the BSP; the duo has been given the responsibility to induct more leaders from the community.

SP leaders, meanwhile, say Akhilesh's support for KCR's initiative is based on his own plans to stop the BJP. At the Khammam rally—also attended by chief ministers Arvind Kejriwal, Bhagwant Mann and Pinarayi Vijayan, besides Communist Party of India general secretary D. Raja—the SP chief spoke about how the Modi government was implementing schemes launched first by KCR in Telangana. The SP thinktank believes that like KCR in Telangana and Mamata Banerjee in West Bengal, as a strong regional party, they too have the capability to stop the BJP juggernaut in UP. So, Akhilesh sees sense in a larger alliance of parties with this similar orientation.

Crucially, the Congress is not in the mix. With only two seats in the UP assembly, Akhilesh doesn't consider it strong enough in the state. Some in the SP, however, think that if the Congress contests all seats in 2024 on its own, it may dent the SP's Muslim vote bank. Akhilesh's lukewarm response to the Bharat Jodo Yatra during its three-day passage through three districts of UP—initially denying he was invited to join, even saying the BJP and Congress "are the same", and later merely RSVP-ing a "thank you"—came as a dampener to the Congress. But it still hopes an alliance with the SP will fructify before the polls. As matters stand, UP is inching towards a fragmented battlefield where, naturally, the BJP senses an opportunity. A senior BJP functionary claims that with the anti-BJP vote divided, the party will get a large number of Lok Sabha seats in 2024. ■

GUJARAT

# THE SHRINKIN

By Jumana Shah

The 'steel frame' of Gujarat is wearing off at the top. Against the centrally sanctioned strength of 313, the state entered the New Year with just 250 Indian Administrative Service (IAS) officers, a shortfall of 20 per cent. With about a dozen officers set to retire in 2023, the shortage—especially in the top echelons—is likely to become even more acute by the end of this year. Chief secretary Pankaj Kumar's eight-month extension, given mainly to maintain continuity during the state assembly election held in December 2022, ended recently. Additional chief secretary (ACS) Raj Kumar has been appointed in his place, superseding Vipul Mittra, who will retire in July this year. Like Mittra, two other secretary-level bureaucrats—B.B. Swain and S. Aparna—are also set to retire this year.

This dearth of senior officers naturally impacts governance. And it often comes to the fore when they are assigned multiple departments of a key nature. For instance, Kamal Dayani, additional chief secretary (ACS), revenue, also heads the Gujarat State Disaster Management Authority. That the latter body is being meted out a stepmotherly treatment was discussed openly in state secretariat circles at the time of the Morbi bridge collapse last year. Similarly, the new chief secretary, Raj Kumar, had been holding the charge of ACS, home, industries and mines, besides heading the Gujarat Industrial Development Corporation, while the Gujarat Maritime Board and Gujarat Pollution Control Board share the same chairman, R.B. Barad. While revenue and home are among the core departments responsible for the government's smooth functioning, the others are technical ones, and are often red-flagged by various industry bodies for alleged red-tapism, putting a question mark on the BJP government's 'ease of doing business' pitch.

In the past decade, Gujarat's IAS cadre strength—sanctioned by the Union department of personnel and training in consultation with the state government—has increased by 20 per cent, up from 260 in 2012. The numbers drafted in annually—anywhere between two and nine officers—obviously do not suffice to meet the demand. In fact, in 2021, when nine new IAS officers were taken in, even that made big news. Historically, the shortage of IAS officers is attributed to a decision taken by the then chief minister, Chimanbhai Patel, in the early '90s to protest against the Centre's stand on the Narmada dam issue—for about four years, Gujarat did not recruit officers through the Union Public Service Commission (UPSC). To fill the vacancies thus created, Chimanbhai opted to promote Gujarat Administrative Service (GAS) officers, who, he asserted, had an "emotional connect" with the state. Several later CMs, including Narendra Modi, continued the preference for state officers

